

Credit - Drishti Ias

Centre Proposes Special Article 371 Framework for Ladakh



Source: TH

Why in News?

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has released the official minutes of its meetings with civil society groups from **Ladakh**, revealing a breakthrough agreement. The Centre has proposed a unique, customized model of **self-governance under Article 371 for the Union Territory of Ladakh**.

- This draft agreement marks a significant step toward resolving years of political deadlock, agitations, and representation deficits in the region.

What is the Proposed Governance Model for Ladakh?

- **A "Sui Generis" Model under Article 371:** Instead of the **Sixth Schedule**, the Centre will implement a customized, **unique (sui generis)** framework drawing from the various provisions of **Article 371 (similar to protections in Nagaland or Mizoram)**.
 - This is intended to legally safeguard Ladakh's tribal culture, land, and local employment.
- **Elected UT-Level Body:** Ladakh will move away from being a purely bureaucrat-run Union Territory.
 - A democratic, Union Territory-level elected body will be established to provide a political voice to the local population.
- **Tripartite Powers:** This new elected body will not just be advisory; it will be vested with distinct **executive, financial, and legislative powers** to govern local subjects.
- **Direct Control Over Bureaucracy:** In a major shift from standard UT administration, the elected executive will have **direct control and supervision over civil servants** who manage subjects under the elected body's purview.
 - This also includes the authority to **review and appraise officials' performance**, making the bureaucracy directly accountable to the elected government.
- **Harmonized Local Governance:** The new overarching legislature will be structured to work in harmony with the grassroots **Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs)**.
- **Statehood as a Long-Term Goal:** While immediate full statehood is not part of this immediate package due to financial constraints (particularly the burden of government salaries), the Centre has

formally acknowledged in the official minutes that Statehood remains the "long-term aspiration" of the Ladakhi people.

Why is Ladakh Demanding Constitutional Safeguards?

- **Reorganisation of Jammu & Kashmir (2019):** In August 2019, the abrogation of [Article 370](#) and the [Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019](#) bifurcated the erstwhile state.
 - Ladakh achieved its long-standing demand to become a separate Union Territory, but it was designated as a **UT *without a legislature***.
- **The "Representation Deficit":** Prior to 2019, Ladakh had four MLAs in the J&K Assembly. Its transition to a UT left all administrative control with the Centre-appointed **Lieutenant Governor**, severely curtailing local democratic representation. The existing **Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDCs)** of Leh and Kargil had limited powers.
- **Agitations (2021-2026):** Fearing demographic changes and loss of land rights, the civil groups spearhead massive protests, shutdowns, and fasts (notably led by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk).
- **The Four-Point Demand:**
 - Full Statehood for Ladakh.
 - Safeguards under the [Sixth Schedule](#) of the Constitution.
 - Establishment of a separate **Ladakh Public Service Commission (LPSC)** for job reservations.
 - Two Parliamentary seats for the region (Leh and Kargil).

India's Constitutional Shields for Tribal Areas	
How the Fifth and Sixth Schedules differ — and what lies beyond	
FIFTH SCHEDULE Art. 244(1) Covers Scheduled Areas & Tribes in all states <i>except</i> Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura & Mizoram Sets up Tribal Advisory Councils — advisory bodies only Limited autonomy	SIXTH SCHEDULE Art. 244(2) Applies to tribal areas in Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura & Mizoram Creates Autonomous District Councils — self-governing bodies Extensive powers
WHAT ADCS CAN DO UNDER THE SIXTH SCHEDULE	
 Manage land & non-reserved forests	 Set up village courts & councils
 Run primary schools & dispensaries	 Levy taxes on land & buildings
 Grant mineral extraction licences	 Control money-lending by non-tribals
Art. 371 A~J The Third Route Special provisions tailored to the political & cultural contexts of specific states — a middle path beyond the Fifth and Sixth Schedules. Nagaland Assam Manipur Andhra Pradesh + 6 more	

Article 371

- **About: Article 371**, under **Part XXI** of the Constitution, provides **special provisions for certain States** to address their unique historical, cultural, social, and regional needs.
 - While **Article 371** has been part of the Constitution since **26 th January 1950**, **Articles 371A**

to 371J were inserted later through constitutional amendments under **Article 368**.

- **Key Feature:** Unlike the Sixth Schedule, which operates via Autonomous Councils, Article 371 empowers the State Legislature or the Governor to protect local customs, religious practices, and customary laws, and restricts the transfer of land to non-residents (e.g., Article 371A for Nagaland).
 - **Article 371** provides for separate Development Boards in **Maharashtra** and **Gujarat** for balanced regional development.
 - Article 371A (Nagaland), Article 371B (Assam), Article 371C (Manipur), Articles 371D & 371E (Andhra Pradesh and Telangana), Article 371F (Sikkim), Article 371G (Mizoram), Article 371H (Arunachal Pradesh), Article 371I (Goa), and Article 371J (Kalyana Karnataka Region of Karnataka).
- **The Proposed Fix:** The Centre argues that a customized Article 371 framework offers Ladakh the same robust protections for land, culture, and jobs without the administrative complexities of the Sixth Schedule.

SPECIAL PROVISIONS FOR SOME STATES

Articles 371 to 371-J in Part XXI of the constitution contain special provisions for 12 states to meet the aspirations, protect cultural & economic interests or to deal with disturbed law & order conditions in the states.

Article 371, Maharashtra and Gujarat

- ⌚ Part of the Constitution since 26 January 1950
- ⌚ Governor responsible*

Article 371A, Nagaland

- ⌚ **Added by:** 13th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1962
- ⌚ Establishment of regional council consisting 35 members for Tuensang district
- ⌚ Governor can make regulations for- peace, progress, law and order & good government
- ⌚ Parliament Acts*

Article 371B, Assam

- ⌚ **Added by:** 22nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1969
- ⌚ President authorized creation of a committee of Legislative assembly (LA) consisting of elected members from Tribal areas

Article 371C, Manipur

- ⌚ **Added by:** 27th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1971
- ⌚ President authorized creation of a committee of LA consisting of elected members of hill areas
- ⌚ Assigns Governor to submit an annual report to the President on the administration

Articles 371 D & E, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana

- ⌚ **Added by:** 32nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1973
- ⌚ **Articles 371 D:**
 - ⌚ President can provide equitable opportunities & facilities to people from Andhra Pradesh in public employment and education
 - ⌚ President is empowered for establishment of administrative tribunals
- ⌚ **Articles 371 E:**
 - ⌚ Empowers Parliament for establishment of Central University

Article 371-F, Sikkim

- ⌚ **Added by:** 36th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1975
- ⌚ Provides respect and preservation of existing laws, customs, & rights by the Parliament
- ⌚ One seat allotted for Sikkim in Lok Sabha and forms one parliamentary constituency
- ⌚ **Members in LA:** ≥30

Article 371-G, Mizoram

- ⌚ **Added by:** 53rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1986
- ⌚ Parliament Acts*
- ⌚ **Members in LA:** ≥ 40

Article 371H, Arunachal Pradesh

- ⌚ **Added by:** 55th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1986
- ⌚ Special responsibility on Governor concerning law and order & ceases on President's direction
- ⌚ **Members in LA:** ≥ 30

Article 371-I, Goa

- ⌚ **Added by:** 56th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1987
- ⌚ **Members in LA:** ≥ 30

Article 371J, Hyderabad-Karnataka Region (Kalyana Karnataka)

- ⌚ **Added by:** 98th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2012
- ⌚ Governor responsible*

NOTE:

Parliament Acts* implies:

- Acts of Parliament not applicable without consent of state assembly on matters:

- ⌚ Religious and social practices
- ⌚ Customary law and procedure
- ⌚ Land rights
- ⌚ Justice

Governor responsible* implies:

■ Governor of the state responsible for:

- ⌚ Establishment of separate development board to make a provision to place a report before state LA annually
- ⌚ Equitable allocation of funds for developmental expenditure
- ⌚ Equitable arrangement (Article 371)/ Reservation of seats (Article 371-J) in educational and vocational training institutions, state government posts

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Why has the Centre proposed an Article 371-based framework for Ladakh instead of the Sixth Schedule?

The Centre believes a **customized Article 371 framework** can safeguard **land, tribal culture, and local employment** while providing greater administrative flexibility than the Sixth Schedule.

2. What are the key features of the proposed governance model for Ladakh?

It proposes an **elected UT-level body** with **executive, financial, and legislative powers**, direct supervision over local bureaucracy, and coordination with **Panchayati Raj Institutions**.

3. What were the major demands raised by Ladakh's civil society groups?

The four key demands were **full statehood, Sixth Schedule status, a separate Ladakh Public Service Commission, and two Parliamentary constituencies**.

4. How does Article 371 differ from the Sixth Schedule?

Article 371 provides **State-specific constitutional safeguards** through special provisions, whereas the **Sixth Schedule** establishes **Autonomous District Councils** with legislative, judicial, and administrative powers in notified tribal areas.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/kMWhcT-dPVk>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Under which Schedule of the Constitution of India can the transfer of tribal land to private parties for mining be declared null and void? (2019)

- (a) Third Schedule
- (b) Fifth Schedule
- (c) Ninth Schedule
- (d) Twelfth Schedule

Ans: (b)

Q. The Government enacted the Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act in 1996. Which one of the following is not identified as its objective? (2013)

- (a) To provide self-governance
- (b) To recognize traditional rights
- (c) To create autonomous regions in tribal areas
- (d) To free tribal people from exploitation

Ans: (c)

Q. Which of the following provisions of the Constitution of India have a bearing on Education? (2012)

1. Directive Principles of State Policy
2. Rural and Urban Local Bodies
3. Fifth Schedule
4. Sixth Schedule
5. Seventh Schedule

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3, 4 and 5 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. To what extent is Article 370 of the Indian Constitution, bearing marginal note “Temporary provision with respect to the State of Jammu and Kashmir”, temporary? Discuss the future prospects of this provision in the context of Indian polity. (2016)

Q. Why are the tribals in India referred to as ‘the Scheduled Tribes? Indicate the major provisions enshrined in the Constitution of India for their upliftment. (2016)

INSA Proposes a Unified National Energy Framework



For Prelims: Renewable energy , National Green Hydrogen Mission , SATAT , PM Surya Ghar , Competitive federalism.

For Mains: India's Energy Transition: Challenges and Policy Reforms, Integrated Energy Governance and the need for a Unified National Energy Framework.

Source: TH

Why in News?

The **Indian National Science Academy (INSA)** , through its **Centre for Science, Technology, Innovation, and Policy (CSTIP)** , has released a **policy brief (May 2026)** advocating a **Unified National Energy Policy Framework** to accelerate India's energy transition and support its goals of **energy self-reliance by 2047** and **net-zero emissions by 2070** .

Summary

- INSA has proposed a **Unified National Energy Framework** to integrate India's fragmented energy policies, strengthen **energy security** , modernize the grid, and support the goals of **Energy Self-Reliance by 2047** and **Net Zero by 2070** .
- The framework emphasizes **grid integration, energy storage, Green Hydrogen, CCUS, Circular Economy, DISCOM reforms, affordability, and a just, region-specific energy transition** to ensure a reliable and sustainable energy ecosystem.

What is a Unified National Energy Policy Framework?

- **About:** It refers to a coordinated and system-integrated governance framework that synergizes policies across various energy domains fossil fuels (coal, oil, gas), renewable energy (solar, wind), electricity distribution, green hydrogen, and climate commitments.
 - Rather than treating different fuels as competing markets, it views the national power grid and energy supply chain as a single, holistic ecosystem.

Need for a Unified Policy Architecture for India's Clean Energy Future

- **Shift From 'Capacity Addition' to 'System Integration':** India's **renewable energy** (RE) capacity scaled from **~40 GW in 2015 to ~260 GW by 2025** .
 - Managing a highly variable 260 GW requires real-time, system-wide integration with base-load thermal power, Pumped Storage Hydropower, and Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) to prevent frequency collapse.
- **The "Silo" Conundrum:** India's energy governance is deeply fractured. Distinct ministries handle specific domains Ministry of Coal, Ministry of Power, Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG), Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), and the **Department of Atomic Energy (DAE)**.
 - This leads to overlapping timelines, regulatory friction, and sub-optimal resource allocation.
 - A unified framework treats coal, gas, biomass, and RE as **complementary feedstocks** rather than competing commercial domains.
- **Supply-Demand Asymmetries** : Supply-side manufacturing mandates are outpacing infrastructure and market off-take readiness.
 - Mega initiatives like the **National Green Hydrogen Mission** and **SATAT (Compressed Biogas)** face severe bottlenecks in midstream evacuation, localized pipeline networks, and uniform pricing.
 - An integrated policy aligns production directly with commercial demand absorption.
- **Eliminating Data Silos:** Critical electricity sector data remains scattered across multiple agencies with non-standardized formats, hindering real-time decision-making, planning, and investment.
 - The **draft National Electricity Data Sharing Framework, 2026** proposes a **National Electricity Data Centre (NEDC)** to standardize electricity data across the power sector, enabling **AI-based grid management, accurate demand forecasting, and integrated energy planning** .
- **Mitigating Fiscal Stress and Import Vulnerabilities:** India remains structurally dependent on foreign imports for **over 85% of its crude oil** , while quantified energy subsidies consume roughly **2.3% of the national GDP** .
 - Fragmented policies drain fiscal resources through uncoordinated subsidies. A unified architecture links demand-side solar schemes (**PM Surya Ghar , PM-KUSUM**) directly with state-level distribution company (DISCOM) structural reforms, while integrating **Carbon Capture (CCUS)** to de-risk hard-to-abate industrial sectors.

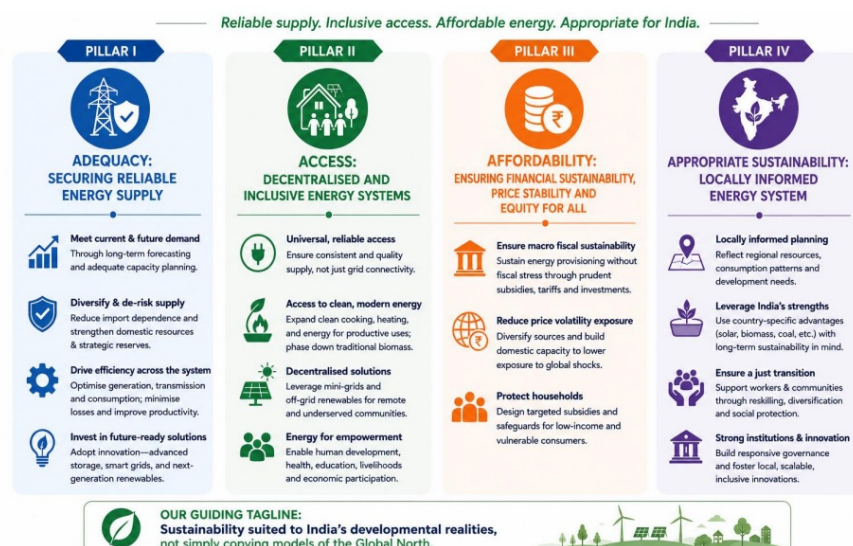
What are the Key Challenges in Implementing a Unified Energy Architecture?

- **Institutional Fragmentation:** A unified architecture requires centralized planning, but creating an apex coordinating mechanism (like a proposed Department of Energy Resources) threatens existing bureaucratic jurisdictions.
 - This fragmentation causes a **"resource-impetus mismatch,"** where thermal and renewable sectors operate with conflicting regulatory timelines.
- **Transmission Deficit:** Generation and transmission planning are completely desynchronized. Renewable Energy (RE) projects have a gestation period of 12–18 months, whereas setting up interstate transmission networks takes 18–30 months.
 - This mismatch leads to massive **grid congestion and power curtailment**. For instance, the tight operating frequency band of India's grid (49.90 Hz to 50.05 Hz) struggles to **handle intermittent solar fluctuations (the "duck curve"), frequently forcing the grid to curtail clean energy**.

- **Massive Energy Storage Gap:** The **Central Electricity Authority (CEA)** projects that **India needs 60.63 GW of energy storage by 2030** (41.65 GW from BESS).
 - As of early 2024, India had only a fraction of this operational, severely constrained by high capital costs and critical mineral import dependencies.
- **DISCOM Financial Distress and Capital Scarcity:** A unified architecture demands astronomical upfront capital for grid modernization, smart metering, and decentralized distribution.
 - The primary buyers of electricity the **State Power Distribution Companies (DISCOMs)** remain structurally debt-ridden. Their persistent financial losses, driven by high AT&C losses and un-rationalized tariffs, severely restrict their ability to invest in grid flexibility and procure expensive integrated clean power.
- **The "Just Transition" and Federal Friction :** A unified, top-down national policy clashes with stark state-level economic realities.
 - Designing a framework that funds local workforce reskilling without crippling state economies remains a massive political challenge under India's model of **competitive federalism**.

What are the Key Highlights of the Proposed INSA Framework?

- **Adequacy:** Focuses on securing a reliable, highly diversified energy supply by balancing a portfolio of conventional and emerging sources. This is to be driven by **modernized infrastructure, grid-scale energy storage, and advanced digital technologies** to mitigate long-term systemic vulnerabilities.
- **Access:** Emphasizes providing reliable, equitable energy services to every citizen by strengthening last-mile delivery networks, enhancing utility service quality, and expanding **decentralized energy solutions** where grid connectivity is unviable.
- **Affordability:** Recognizes that the clean energy transition must remain economically viable for households, commercial businesses, and heavy industries. This will be achieved by deploying **innovative financing mechanisms, maximizing market efficiencies, and structuring consumer-focused safeguards** .
- **Appropriate Sustainability:** Rejects a "one-size-fits-all" template, advocating instead for climate solutions tailored to **India's unique social, economic, and environmental context** . This includes targeted support for local communities, workforce development, and region-specific transition pathways.



Strategic Enablers and Emerging Technologies Highlighted

- **Cross-Cutting Technical Levers:** The framework identifies **Circular Economy practices** and **Carbon Capture, Utilisation, and Storage (CCUS)** as mandatory mechanisms to complement renewable energy and aggressively abate emissions in hard-to-decarbonize industrial sectors.
- **Green Hydrogen and Clean Tech:** Immediate prioritization is placed on accelerating the commercial scaling and infrastructure deployment of **green hydrogen** alongside advanced bio-resources.
- **Resource Optimization:** The architecture treats coal, renewables, biomass, natural gas, and waste-to-energy systems not as isolated, competing sectors, but as interdependent components of a single, interconnected national energy asset.

Conclusion

India's Near-Term Priorities must focus on breaking ministerial silos, fast-tracking interstate transmission infrastructure to eliminate renewable energy curtailment, and deploying cost-effective grid-scale energy storage.

Concurrently, the **Long-Term Evolution** of India's energy landscape should rely on deeply integrating low-carbon technologies like Green Hydrogen, expanding circular bio-resources, and commercializing CCUS. This phased transition will successfully bridge the gap between regional socioeconomic realities and the national imperative of a resilient, net-zero energy ecosystem.

Drishti Mains Question:

Discuss the need for a Unified National Energy Framework in achieving India's energy security and climate goals. Examine the challenges in its implementation.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Unified National Energy Framework proposed by INSA?

It is a **coordinated energy governance framework** that integrates policies across **fossil fuels, renewable energy, electricity, green hydrogen, and climate commitments** to ensure a reliable and sustainable energy system.

2. Why does India need a Unified National Energy Framework?

It aims to **eliminate policy fragmentation**, improve **grid integration**, strengthen **energy security**, reduce import dependence, and support India's **Net Zero 2070** and **Energy Self-Reliance 2047** goals.

3. What are the four pillars of the proposed INSA Framework?

The framework is based on **Adequacy, Access, Affordability, and Appropriate Sustainability**, ensuring reliable, inclusive, affordable, and region-specific energy development.

4. What are the major challenges in implementing the Unified Energy Framework?

Key challenges include **institutional fragmentation, transmission bottlenecks, inadequate energy storage, financially stressed DISCOMs**, and ensuring a just transition for coal-dependent states.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Limited (IREDA), which of the following statements is/are correct? (2015)

1. It is a Public Limited Government Company.
2. It is a Non-Banking Financial Company.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q. “Access to affordable, reliable, sustainable and modern energy is the sine qua non to achieve Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)”. Comment on the progress made in India in this regard. **(2018)**

MANAS: Digital Platform Against Drug Abuse

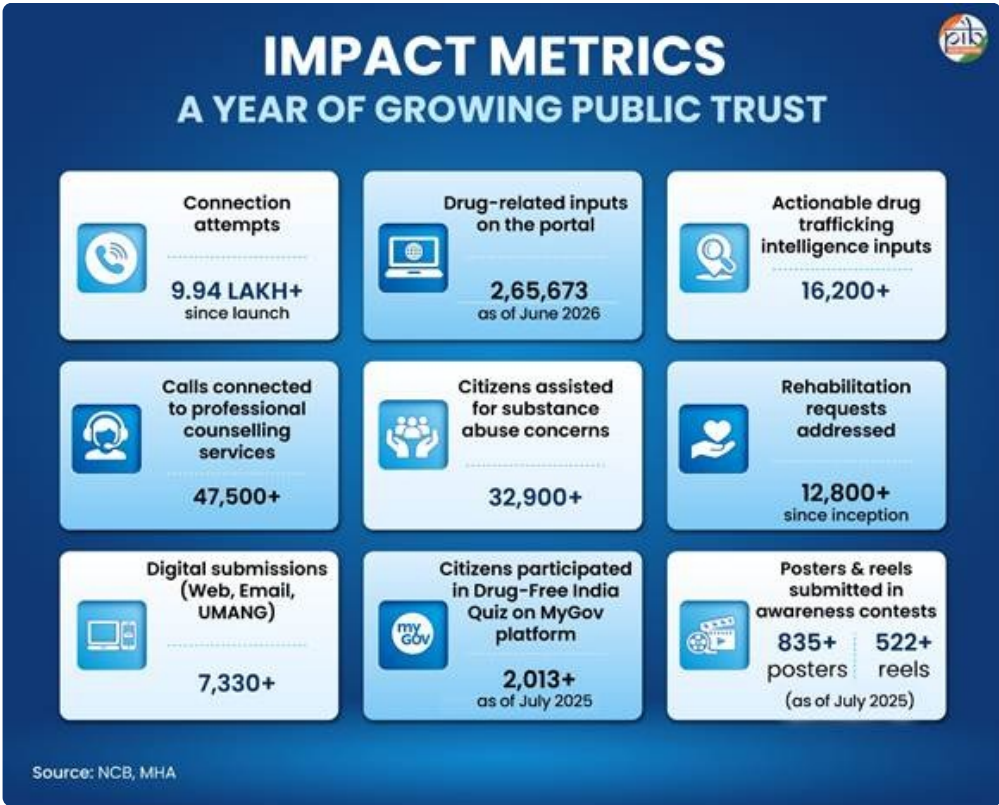


Source: PIB

In response to **India’s growing drug abuse and trafficking challenge**, the Government has strengthened technology-enabled citizen participation through initiatives such as **MANAS**, alongside public-health and law-enforcement measures to achieve a [Nasha Mukh Bharat](#).

- **About:** Launched on 18th July 2024, MANAS stands for Madak Padarth Nishedh Asoochna Kendra and serves as India’s National Narcotics Helpline under the Narcotics Control Bureau, Ministry of Home Affairs.
- **Access and Partners:** It has been developed with Digital India Corporation and is accessible through helpline 1933, official portal, email and [UMANG app](#).
- **Core Objective:** It enables citizens to confidentially report drug trafficking, peddling, illegal cultivation and other drug-related activities without revealing their identity.

- **Counselling and Rehabilitation:** Persons affected by addiction can access counselling and de-addiction support, with relevant calls transferred to the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment helpline 14446.
- **Digital Workflow:** The platform uses digital ticket generation, workflow management, report tracking and data analytics to improve coordination, identify hotspots and speed up agency response.
- **Agency Linkage:** MANAS connects citizens with 30 NCB Zonal Units and 36 State/UT Anti-Narcotics Task Forces for coordinated anti-drug action.
- **Significance:** MANAS strengthens secure reporting, counselling access, digital governance, inter-agency coordination and citizen-led action against drug abuse and trafficking.



Read More: [Towards Drug Free India](#)

Inaugural India–Mali Forum for Promotion of Exports



Source: PIB

In a significant stride toward cementing economic ties in the West African region, India and Mali

officially institutionalized their commercial partnership by organizing the **inaugural India-Mali Forum for the Promotion of Exports** in Bamako under the theme "**Reinforcing Trade and Strategic Partnerships.**"

Key Takeaways from the India-Mali Export Forum

- **Bilateral Trade Surge:** Bilateral trade between the two nations witnessed an impressive **55% year-on-year growth** , surpassing **USD 326.61 million in FY 2025-26** .
- **Catalyst for Trade:** India's **Duty-Free Tariff Preference (DFTP) Scheme** has emerged as the primary catalyst in driving and strengthening this bilateral trade trajectory.
- **Untapped Market Potential:** Against Mali's global exports of approximately US\$ 4 billion, the **untapped export potential for Malian goods in the Indian market is estimated at nearly USD 3.96 billion** .
- **Key Trade Commodities:**
 - **Mali's Exports to India:** Raw cotton, finished leather, cashew, lead, gum arabic, and sesame.
 - **India's Exports to Mali:** Pharmaceuticals, cotton fabrics, two- and three-wheelers, and bicycles.
- **Priority Sectors Identified:** Both nations earmarked **cotton and textiles, mining and energy, agro-industry and shea processing, pharmaceuticals, and social infrastructure (health and education)** for future joint ventures and investments.
- **Mutual Administrative Requests:** Mali sought Indian support for **digitizing its Certificate of Origin system** and faster registration of Indian pharmaceuticals, while India requested a **reconsideration of Mali's shea-nut export ban** and emphasized the **protection of Indian nationals and investments** .
- **Future Roadmap:** Mali positioned itself as a strategic investment hub for West Africa under its **Vision Mali 2063 roadmap** and announced a dedicated **Investment Forum to be held in December, 2026** , to present bankable projects to international investors.

Mali

- **Location:** Mali is a **landlocked country in West Africa** , situated in the **Sahara and Sahel regions** .
 - It shares borders with **Algeria (North), Niger and Burkina Faso (East), Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea (South), and Senegal and Mauritania (West).**
- **Capital:** **Bamako**
- **Major Rivers:** **Niger River** (lifeline of the country) and **Senegal River** .
- **Highest Peak:** **Mount Hombori (1,155 m)** .
- **Climate:** Predominantly **hot, arid, and semi-arid** , influenced by the **Harmattan** and **Alizé** winds.
- **Major Physiographic Regions:** **Sahara Desert (North), Sahel (Central), and Sudanian Savanna (South).**
- **Economy:** A **low-income, agriculture-dependent economy** , with **gold** as the largest export, alongside **cotton, livestock, and fishing** . Important minerals include **iron, bauxite, manganese, and lithium** .
- **Historical Significance:** Once part of the **Ghana, Mali, and Songhai Empires** ; **Timbuktu** was a renowned centre of **trans-Saharan trade and Islamic learning** .



Read more: [Deepening India-Africa Engagement](#)

I-2SEA Submarine Cable System Unveiled



Source: TH

A consortium comprising Microsoft, Singtel, Tata Communications and Lightstorm has signed contracts to build the **India-Southeast Asia (I-2SEA) submarine cable system** to meet the rising demand for **AI , cloud and hyperscaler connectivity across the India-Southeast Asia** corridor.

- **About:** I-2SEA is a **submarine cable system with carrier-neutral landing infrastructure**, connecting India's east coast with Malaysia and Singapore and linking key AI and cloud infrastructure hubs in the region.
 - Submarine cables are undersea **fibre-optic cables that carry large volumes of internet**, telecom and data traffic, forming the backbone of global digital connectivity.
- **Route and Landings:** The system will have dual landing stations in India at **Machilipatnam and South Chennai**, with Machilipatnam providing the shortest subsea access to Hyderabad, and onward connectivity to Mumbai and over 80 data centres through Lightstorm's terrestrial network.
- **Purpose:** The cable is designed to serve **hyperscalers, GPU infrastructure providers and enterprises running AI training and inference workloads**, while enabling high-capacity, low-latency digital connectivity.
- **Features:** The system will feature **interoperable cable architecture, carrier-neutral landing infrastructure, deep cable burial for enhanced protection**, and integration with Lightstorm's SmartNet AI Fabric and Polarin platform for unified network management.
- **Significance:** Expected to be **operational by Q4 2029** , the approximately 3,600-km cable will strengthen India-Southeast Asia digital connectivity, support the growth of AI and cloud ecosystems, and provide one of the fastest transmission routes between Singapore/Malaysia and Hyderabad.

Read more: [India's Emerging Technology Ecosystem](#)